

Whose Country?

Facebook is now yet another cause of angst in West Asia. Jewish settlers in West Bank were pissed off when Facebook auto completed their country as Palestine. After angry protests it now offers Israel as another option, even though West Bank is not part of Israel. Well, as they say you can't please all.



Remote Service

Undertakers and funeral parlours are embracing the Internet with gusto. They make money—lots of it—by webcasting funeral services for families whose members might be scattered all over the globe. For a fee of £75 (about Rs 5,974) you can watch a funeral live (with 20 seconds delay) or up to 7 days later. DVD's of the funeral can be obtained for £50 (about Rs 3,982).



Escape

BORNE IDENTITY

Life's Labour Lost

Now this is what classifies as starting over from a clean slate. This is a scenario that all of us (yep, even billionaires and star kids) face at least once in our lives. Namely, could we not forget every thing bad that happened to us during the course of our sorry existence and start over new, like virgin plastic? Or,

a shiny new coin fresh out from the mint.

Apparently you can, if you have an eBay account. Because this was what a bloke from Down Under planned to achieve. Ian Usher was so heartbroken by a messy divorce that he could not bear to look at his house, his friends, his job and even his parachuting equipment because all of them reminded him of his ex. He therefore decided to sell all of them to the highest bidder on the Internet. Well actually only the house, with friends and the job thrown in as sweetener. So if you have about \$390,000 or thereabouts you can live in his house, hang out at the pub with his mates, have a crack at his job and also jump out of airplanes strapped to his parachute. He has actually settled up



with his friends and boss, so that the hanging out part need not start with awkward introductions. As for the man himself, he has decided that he will take the cash and go to far off lands.

We hope he would not have to run another such ad seven years down the line in some other part of the world. Oh, and we concur with Obelix—the Internet is crazy.

HOW MANY WAYS?

Mercy Killing

We know that eggheads sometimes get crazy and pick up the unlikeliest topics to write a research paper. One such paper is about the different types of video game deaths, and their co relation with the rush of hormones that bring forth a giddy rush.

At first glance, the conclusions seem to be totally counter-intuitive. Gamers like it when they

Whatever Happened To...

Gopher

It's odd that an Internet protocol should be named after a rodent. If you look through your browser's proxy settings, you'll find it listed right there—where did it come from, and where did it go?

The Gopher protocol is supposed to be a souped-up version of Anonymous FTP—souped up because of the search capabilities it provided. It organises information in a strict hierarchy, and no-nonsense text menus would ensure that Gopher servers don't suffer with slow connections. All that promise...what happened?

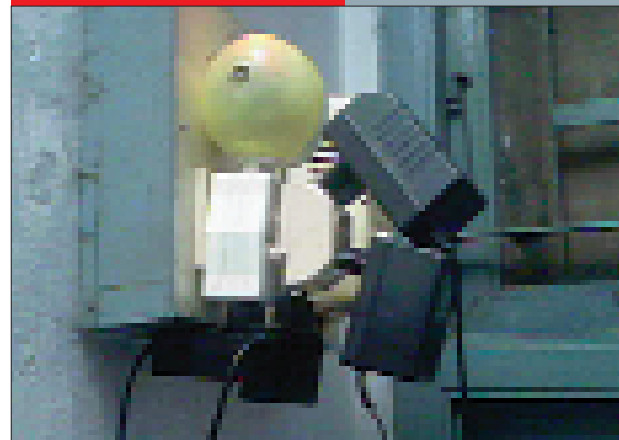
It all began with greed—the University of Minnesota (the developers) decided one day that it would charge a licensing fee for the Gopher server. "The hell you are", said the world, and HTTP climbed the popularity charts. The protocol's since been released under the GPL, but the damage's been done.

Moreover, HTML offered much more flexibility and prettiness when it came to content, and the marketing guys loved it.

There are less than a hundred Gopher servers alive today, if you can really call them "alive"—they're just...well...there. One such site is Gopher Jewels (gopher://home.jumpjet.info/1%5CGopher_Jewels_2), which is something of a "the best of Gopher" collection. Visit, and enjoy.

DigiPick of the month

Asking for trouble



Last month's winner:

Rajarajan P
Kanchipuram

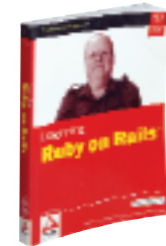
Corrigendum—February's Winner:

Debiprasad Sahoo
Chennai

Participate and win next month:
Beginning Ruby on Rails
by Steve Holzner

Published by

WILEY-INDIA



WIN!

Send in your entry and you could win an exciting gift by sharing an amusing picture with a tech angle to it. The picture should have been shot by you, and should not have been published anywhere earlier. E-mail your picture with "DigiPick" in the subject line, mentioning your postal address, **on or before the 20th of this month to digipick@thinkdigit.com**. One prize-winning picture will be published each month.

are killed, and they enjoy the different and convoluted ways in which their character dies. While we don't want to believe that, the elaborate set up rigged by the Niklas Ravajas leaves no room for ambiguity. Thirty-six gamers were wired up sensors while they were doing what they did best. Based on the readings of the sensors, Ravajas found that gamers cringe involuntary when they shoot their enemies while gloat when they get killed. Well, not exactly gloat but more like breathe easier. This is because the paper reasons that games have become more stressful as levels become tougher and the players have to fight more to save their skin. At one point of time this caper gets too much to handle and subconsciously the players start to think, enough is enough and run into a wall of hot lead or lasers and get blasted to Kingdom Come.

In fact, some game designers have taken the trouble to craft death sequences which make it worthwhile to die. Games like Halo 3 switch the

camera angle as you die so it's like an out of body experience as you see yourself zapped by lasers or blasted by grenades, falling down in slow motion.

Admit it—you always wanted to do that after seeing how Tom Hanks died in *Saving Private Ryan*, or how Ken Watanabe and company went down in that final charge in *The Last Samurai*.

FOAM AND FONE TOGETHER!

Bath Connected

Quick: connect anime, high-tech gizmos, green tea and luxurious public baths. Well the anime part was a dead giveaway. The Japanese, we hear, are compulsive gadget freaks and have a need to keep changing their mobile phones with a little less frequency than they change clothes. But it turns out that even in that short period of time they are incredibly attached to their phones. So attached that they can't pry those phones

off even when they have to go bathing!

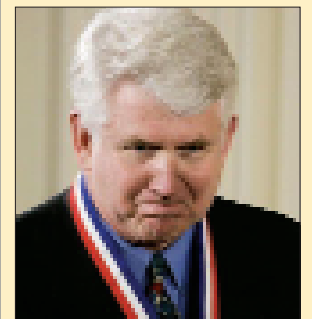
This habit has been helped by the fact that the Japanese don't take showers like the rest of us. No sir, their idea of bathing is a huge hall with a tub the size of an Olympic swimming pool. Hundreds maybe would congregate together and enjoy a refreshing (?) dip in the waters while catching up with politics. At least that's what used to happen during the good old days. In the mobile phone age everyone and their cousin are seen waist downwards in water and a mobile phone stuck to their ears. Statisticians, after a glance at their charts and graphs tell us that young people do most of the talking. They also helpfully inform us that writing emails and listening to music are also hot favourites.

In case you are wondering what happens when water enters the mobile phones, hold your horses. Japanese manufacturers had already foreseen this and sell their phones as bath-safe, presumably for an extra thousand yen.

People Who Changed Computing

Robert "Bob" M. Metcalfe

One man is the reason you're able to transfer gigabytes of data over your local network. That one man's name is Bob Metcalfe, and he's the father of the Ethernet—the reason you can connect to another PC for work, and for play.



Robert "Bob" M. Metcalfe

In March 1973, Metcalfe, along with his colleague David Boggs at the Xerox Palo Alto Research Centre (PARC), developed the system which we now fondly call the LAN. The official "day the Ethernet was born" was May 22, 1973, though November 11—the day it actually worked—would be more accurate. He was awarded the IEEE Medal of Honor in 1996 for the development, standardising and commercialisation of Ethernet.

Metcalfe studied Electrical Engineering at MIT, and followed it up with another from MIT's Sloan School of Management.

After leaving PARC, Metcalfe founded 3Com Corp—specialists in networking hardware. In 1990, he left 3Com to become a columnist for InfoWorld, before becoming a venture capitalist in 2001. Today, he's the director of PopTech—a technology conference he co-founded.

Win!

My Desktop

Bitangsha Ray, Kolkata

How he did it:

1. Create a new page in FrontPage 2003
2. Go to Insert > Web Component, choose Photo Slideshow. Locate all your photos. Choose a size for the enlarged photo
3. Save this page and set it as the desktop
4. Change your wallpaper by clicking the photograph

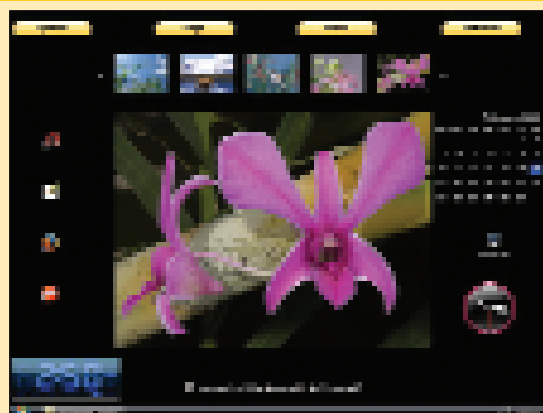
Participate in this contest and win next month

.net Interview Questions

by Nagaraju B

Published by

WILEY-INDIA



Send us your desktop with a description of how you made it to **mydesktop@thinkdigit.com** with the subject "My Desktop", and tell us your postal address, too.